

ENGLISH 102 READINGS AND ASSIGNMENTS



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English 102 Readings and Assignments by
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Detailed Licensing

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Writing a Cause/Effect or Problem-Solution Essay About Unconscious Bias

Students will review selected texts and a video about unconscious bias to prepare a cause/effect or problem-solution argumentative essay.

[1.1: Writing a Cause/Effect or Problem-Solution Essay About Unconscious Bias--Readings and Media](#)

[1.2: Unconscious Bias--Paper Assignment](#)

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1.1: Writing a Cause/Effect or Problem-Solution Essay About Unconscious Bias--Readings and Media

Preparing for the Argumentative Essay on Unconscious Bias

Purpose: to reflect and write about the impact of unconscious bias in various settings with the goal of writing an argumentative essay examining the causes and/or effects or exploring a problem-solution to the issue, based on personal experience and researched information.

This assignment, furthermore, will enable students to fulfill the following course objectives:

- 1) Develop students' writing process in composing formal, college-level essays using various rhetorical writing modes
- 2) Cultivate students' awareness of purpose and audience when assessing a writing situation
- 4) Develop students' abilities in critical thinking, college-level reading, and integrating source material

Task:

Read and watch the required following texts and videos, which provide an overview of unconscious and implicit bias. These materials will provide a starting point for subsequent writing tasks on this topic. You should take notes on the material for future reference:

Read "Unconscious Bias: Definition and Examples," which is linked in the citation.

Nikolopoulou, Kassiani, and Tegan George. "What Is Unconscious Bias?: Definition & Examples." *Scribbr*, 9 Aug. 2024, www.scribbr.com/research-bias/unconscious-bias/.

Watch the "Concepts Unwrapped: Implicit Bias" video linked in the citation.

PBS. "Concepts Unwrapped: Implicit Bias." *PBS LearningMedia*, WNET, 25 Jan. 2021, illinois.pblearningmedia.org/resource/cb19.ss.cuimplicitbias/concepts-unwrapped-implicit-bias/.

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1.2: Unconscious Bias--Paper Assignment

Student Learning Outcomes: upon completion of this assignment, students should be able to:

- 1) Engage in a recursive process of prewriting, drafting, revising, editing, and proofreading
- 3) Employ a voice, style, and tone appropriate to the topic selected and the rhetorical situation
- 4) Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience
- 5) Establish a clear framework of essay and paragraph organization appropriate to the writing task and the thesis
- 6) Employ rhetorical strategies consistent with the purpose of the writing task
- 8) Incorporate reasoning and explanations appropriate to the thesis and its supporting claims

Writing Prompt: prepare a 5-to-6-page argumentative essay about one specific type of unconscious bias in a specific situation (i.e. the workplace, college classroom, health care, etc.). To find other examples of unconscious bias, you may consider please read "19 Unconscious Biases to Overcome and Help Promote Inclusivity," linked in the citation below.

Team Asana. "19 Unconscious Biases to Overcome and Help Promote Inclusivity." Asana, 4 Jan. 2025, asana.com/resources/unconscious-bias-examples.

Once you identify your chosen unconscious bias in a specific situation, explore your position by answering the following questions:

- What claim do you want to state about your selected unconscious bias?
- Who is the audience for your argument?
- List a minimum of three reasons you will use to support your claim.
- What are the counterarguments to your claim?
- What are possible solutions to address the issue?

As you prepare to write the essay, the paper should use **one** of the following structures:

Causes and/or effects (you can focus on a specific cause, a specific effect, or examine both)

[Writing for Success: Cause and Effect](#) provides an overview

Problem-Solution (identify the problem and argue for a specific, practical solution to address the issues) [Problem-Solution Essay Outline](#) provides an overview

Additionally, your essay must use at least three to five reputable sources. Sources may include interviews, journal articles, books, articles, etc. A Works Cited Page using current MLA guidelines is required.

Rubric:

Criteria	Excellent	Good	Satisfactory	Needs Improvement	Unacceptable
Introduction/Thesis Statement	Exceptionally clear, strong, well-written intro that captures the reader's interest. Thesis statement is clearly worded, arguable, and focused.	Introduction captures the reader's interest and provides an overview of the topic. Thesis statement is strong and clear	Adequate introductory paragraph that announces the paper's focus Thesis statement is somewhat clear and arguable but requires rewording to sharpen the focus	Weak introductory paragraph that does not clearly announce the paper's focus Thesis statement is vaguely worded and unclear	Introductory paragraph is missing or is focused on a specific topic broad or multiple topics) Thesis statement not arguable, factual, or missing
Organization/Development of Ideas	All main points are exceptionally well-developed in five or more pages of text Writer provides specific, effective textual examples Writer demonstrates a thorough, logical, insightful analysis of the image. Clear transition usage between all paragraphs	Main points are well-developed in five pages of text minimum Writer provides some appropriate details and examples Writer demonstrates a logical analysis of the image which includes some insight Effective transition usage between most paragraphs	Main points are fairly well-explained though additional textual evidence is needed to strengthen the analysis Writer occasionally states unsupported generalizations or unimportant details Writer demonstrates a basic understanding of the topic with limited insight Most ideas are signaled by paragraph divisions and transition usage	Lack of consistent paragraph usage indicates writer's inability to effectively organize ideas Several main points are not adequately developed Writer frequently uses irrelevant or redundant ideas Writer offers minimal understanding of the topic with insufficient insight Infrequent usage of transitions	Writer fails to explain all main points; relationship between ideas is unclear, undeveloped, or vague Writer does not demonstrate understanding the topic No transition usage

Style/Language Awareness	Precise, appropriate word choice Writer's style illustrates strong control of sentence structure	Writer uses clear language and usually appropriate word choice Essay illustrates writer's good control of sentence structure	Writer uses generally appropriate vocabulary Essay illustrates simple and/or complex sentences with few errors in syntax usages	Writer consistently uses inappropriate language, given the assignment's context Significant problems with sentence structure results in an unclear expression of ideas	Writer confused and/or uses language resulting in unreadable essay Tangled or unclear sentence structure
Grammar, Spelling, and Punctuation	Correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation 1 or 2 typos or careless errors	With few exceptions, correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation 3 to 4 typos or careless errors	Usually correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation 5 to 7 typos or careless errors One to three serious errors (run-ons, fragments, comma splices, subject-verb agreement, verb form concerns)	Recurrent grammar and/or punctuation concerns (run-ons, fragments, comma splices, subject-verb agreement, verb form errors) that disrupts the expression of ideas Recurrent misspellings Pattern of typos or careless errors (8 to 10)	Excessive and disruptive errors in grammar, spelling, and punctuation results in an unclear expression of ideas; the essay is unreadable Writer fails to proofread the essay or more typos or careless errors
Conclusion	Excellent summary of topic with no introduction of new information Writer concludes the analysis on a strong note	Conclusion is clear, strong, and provides a summation of the topic Answers the "so what?" question	To some extent, the conclusion brings closure to the essay A more forceful ending is required	The conclusion is incomplete or does not answer the "so what?" question	Writer fails to provide a conclusion The essay ends abruptly The writer introduces one or more new topics

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Audience and Purpose in Argumentative Writing

SLO-Employ a voice, style, and tone appropriate to the topic selected and the rhetorical situation. ; Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience

Intro: in this module, students will learn the importance of identifying and knowing the audience and their purpose in argumentative writing.

[2.1: Reading About Audience and Purpose](#)

[2.2: Classroom Activity- Identifying and Evaluating the Author's Purpose and Audience](#)

[2.3: Writing Assignment](#)

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2.1: Reading About Audience and Purpose

Read: read the following text from Lumen FASTrack WRIT 102 Writing Guide (CC BY NA SA)

SLO: Employ a voice, style, and tone appropriate to the topic selected and the rhetorical situation; Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience.

Identifying Audience and Purpose

Audience matters

When you're in the process of writing a paper, it's easy to forget that you are actually writing to someone. Whether you've thought about it consciously or not, you always write to an audience: sometimes your audience is a very generalized group of readers, sometimes you know the individuals who compose the audience, and sometimes you write for yourself. Keeping your audience in mind while you write can help you make good decisions about what material to include, how to organize your ideas, and how best to support your argument.

To illustrate the impact of audience, imagine you're writing a letter to your grandmother to tell her about your first month of college. What details and stories might you include? What might you leave out? Now imagine that you're writing on the same topic but your audience is your best friend. Unless you have an extremely cool grandma to whom you're very close, it's likely that your two letters would look quite different in terms of content, structure, and even tone.

Isn't my instructor my audience?

Yes, your instructor is probably the actual audience for your paper. Your instructors read and grade your essays, and you want to keep their needs and perspectives in mind when you write. However, when you write an essay with only your instructor in mind, you might not say as much as you should or say it as clearly as you should, because you assume that the person grading it knows more than you do and will fill in the gaps. This leaves it up to the instructor to decide what you are really saying, and she might decide differently than you expect. For example, she might decide that those gaps show that you don't know and understand the material. Remember that time when you said to yourself, "I don't have to explain communism; my instructor knows more about that than I do" and got back a paper that said something like "Shows no understanding of communism"? That's an example of what can go awry when you think of your instructor as your only audience.

Thinking about your audience differently can improve your writing, especially in terms of how clearly you express your argument. The clearer your points are, the more likely you are to have a strong essay. Your instructor will say, "He really understands communism—he's able to explain it simply and clearly!" By treating your instructor as an intelligent but uninformed audience, you end up addressing her more effectively.

How do I identify my audience and what they want from me?

Before you even begin the process of writing, take some time to consider who your audience is and what they want from you. Use the following questions to help you identify your audience and what you can do to address their wants and needs.

- Who is your audience?
- Might you have more than one audience? If so, how many audiences do you have? List them.
- Does your assignment itself give any clues about your audience?
- What does your audience need? What do they want? What do they value?
- What is most important to them?
- What are they least likely to care about?
- What kind of organization would best help your audience understand and appreciate your ideas? What do you have to say (or what are you doing in your research) that might surprise your audience?
- What do you want your audience to think, learn, or assume about you? What impression do you want your writing or your research to convey?

How much should I explain?

This is the hard part. As we said earlier, you want to show your instructor that you know the material. But different assignments call for varying degrees of information. Different fields also have different expectations. For more about what each field tends to expect from an essay, see the UNC Writing Center [handouts](#) on writing in specific fields of study. The best place to start figuring out how much you should say about each part of your paper is in a careful reading of the assignment. The UNC Writing Center

gives you some tips for reading assignments and figuring them out in their handout on [how to read an assignment](#). The assignment may specify an audience for your paper; sometimes the instructor will ask you to imagine that you are writing to your congressperson, for a professional journal, to a group of specialists in a particular field, or for a group of your peers. If the assignment doesn't specify an audience, you may find it most useful to imagine your classmates reading the paper, rather than your instructor.

Now, knowing your imaginary audience, what other clues can you get from the assignment? If the assignment asks you to summarize something that you have read, then your reader wants you to include more examples from the text than if the assignment asks you to interpret the passage. Most assignments in college focus on argument rather than the repetition of learned information, so your reader probably doesn't want a lengthy, detailed, point-by-point summary of your reading (book reports in some classes and argument reconstructions in philosophy classes are big exceptions to this rule). If your assignment asks you to interpret or analyze the text (or an event or idea), then you want to make sure that your explanation of the material is focused and not so detailed that you end up spending more time on examples than on your analysis. If you are not sure about the difference between explaining something and analyzing it, see the UNC handouts on [reading the assignment](#) and [argument](#).

Once you have a draft, try your level of explanation out on a friend, a classmate, or a Writing Center tutor. Get the person to read your rough draft and then ask her to talk to you about what she did and didn't understand. (Now is not the time to talk about proofreading stuff, so make sure she ignores those issues for the time being). You will likely get one of the following responses or a combination of them:

- If your listener/reader has many questions about what you are saying, then you probably need to explain more. Let's say you are writing a paper on piranhas, and your reader says, "What's a piranha? Why do I need to know about them? How would I identify one?" Those are vital questions that you clearly need to answer in your paper. You need more detail and elaboration.
- If your reader seems confused, you probably need to explain more clearly. So if he says, "Are there piranhas in the lakes around here?" you may not need to give more examples, but rather focus on making sure your examples and points are clear.
- If your reader looks bored and can repeat back to you more details than she needs to know to get your point, you probably explained too much. Excessive detail can also be confusing because it can bog the reader down and keep her from focusing on your main points. You want your reader to say, "So it seems like your paper is saying that piranhas are misunderstood creatures that are essential to South American ecosystems," not, "Uh ... piranhas are important?" or, "Well, I know you said piranhas don't usually attack people, and they're usually around 10 inches long, and some people keep them in aquariums as pets, and dolphins are one of their predators, and ... a bunch of other stuff, I guess?"

Sometimes it's not the amount of explanation that matters but the word choice and tone you adopt. Your word choice and tone need to match your audience's expectations. For example, imagine you are researching piranhas; you find an article in *National Geographic* and another one in an academic journal for scientists. How would you expect the two articles to sound? *National Geographic* is written for a popular audience; you might expect it to have sentences like "The piranha generally lives in shallow rivers and streams in South America." The scientific journal, on the other hand, might use much more technical language, because it's written for an audience of specialists. A sentence like "Serrasalmus piraya lives in fresh and brackish intercoastal and proto-arboreal sub-tropical regions between the 45th and 38th parallels" might not be out of place in the journal.

Generally, you want your reader to know enough material to understand the points you are making. It's like the old forest/trees metaphor. If you give the reader nothing but trees, she won't see the forest (your thesis, the reason for your paper). If you give her a big forest and no trees, she won't know how you got to the forest (she might say, "Your point is fine, but you haven't proven it to me"). You want the reader to say, "Nice forest, and those trees really help me to see it." The UNC Writing Center handout on [paragraph development](#) can help you find a good balance of examples and explanation.

Putting yourself in the reader's position

Instead of reading your draft as if you wrote it and know what you meant, try reading it as if you have no previous knowledge of the material. Have you explained enough? Are the connections clear? This can be hard to do at first. Consider using one of the following strategies:

- Take a break from your work—go work out, take a nap, take a day off. This is why the Writing Center and your instructors encourage you to start writing more than a day before the paper is due. If you write the paper the night before it's due, you make it almost impossible to read the paper with a fresh eye.
- Try outlining after writing—after you have a draft, look at each paragraph separately. Write down the main point for each paragraph on a separate sheet of paper in the order you have put them. Then look at your "outline"—does it reflect what you

meant to say, in a logical order? Are some paragraphs hard to reduce to one point? Why? This technique will help you find places where you may have confused your reader by straying from your original plan for the paper.

- Read the paper aloud—once you get used to it, you’ll see that it helps you slow down and really consider how your reader experiences your text. It will also help you catch a lot of sentence-level errors, such as misspellings and missing words, which can make it difficult for your reader to focus on your argument.

These techniques can help you read your paper in the same way your reader will and make revisions that help your reader understand your argument. Then, when your instructor finally reads your finished draft, he or she won’t have to fill in any gaps. The more work you do, the less work your audience will have to do—and the more likely it is that your instructor will follow and understand your argument.

The Rhetorical Situation:

Ethos—Appeals to the credibility, reputation, and trustworthiness of the speaker or writer (most closely associated with the voice)

Pathos—Appeals to the emotions and cultural beliefs of the listeners or readers (most closely associated with the audience)

Logos—Appeals to reason, logic, and facts in the argument (most closely associated with the message)

Each of these appeals relies on a certain type of evidence: ethical, emotional, or logical. Based on your audience and purpose, you have to decide what combination of techniques will work best as you present your case.

This section will show you how to use both the corners and the sides of the rhetorical triangle as tools for thinking, planning, and writing. Notice how these choices you make about purpose, message, audience, and voice are never made in isolation.

Purpose:

You may think that purpose can be boiled down to one of these single verbs or phrases:

To analyze	To ask for support	To call to action	To clarify	To convince
To counter a previously stated opinion	To describe	To entertain	To inform	To make a request
To make people think	To persuade	To share feelings	To state an opinion	To summarize

However, your real purposes for writing are really more complicated, interesting, and dynamic than this simple list. Purpose involves all three sides and all three corners of the rhetorical triangle: not only do you want to make your audience feel or think a certain way about your message, but you also want to explore and refine your own thoughts and feelings about that message, and furthermore, you want to establish a certain kind of relationship with your audience through the act of conveying your message to them.

Audience:

Sometimes your instructor will specify the audience for an essay assignment, but more often than not, this choice will be left up to you. If it’s your call, ask yourself, “Who would benefit the most from receiving this message?” Not asking that simple question, not choosing a specific audience for your essay, will be a missed opportunity to sharpen your skills as a communicator. By identifying your audience, you can conjecture how much your readers will know about your topic and thus gauge the level of information you should provide. You can determine what kind of tone is best for your audience (e.g., formal or informal, humorous or serious). Based on what you know about your audience, you can even decide the form you want your writing to take (e.g., whether to write a descriptive or more persuasive essay). Knowing your audience will guide many of the other choices you make along the way.

Message:

Regardless of whether your topic is assigned to you or you come up with it on your own, you still have some room to develop your message. Often, especially in academic writing, this message will be in the form of an argumentative thesis statement. Be prepared to revise your message once you have fleshed out your own thinking about it and sharpened your sense of audience and purpose thinking.

Voice:

Regardless of whether you're writing in an academic or a nonacademic context, you draw from a range of voices to achieve a variety of purposes. Each of the purposes listed above has an appropriate voice. If you are writing an essay to fulfill a class assignment, with your instructor as your primary if not exclusive audience, then your voice has pretty much been established for you. In such an instance, you are a student writing in a traditional academic context, subject to the evaluation of your instructor as an expert authorized to judge your work. But even in this most restrictive case, you should still try to develop a distinctive voice based on what you hope to accomplish through your writing. Once you have identified your purposes and the corners of the rhetorical triangle, it's time to do some preliminary thinking about the relationships between those corners— that is, the sides: voice and message (attitude), message and audience (reception), and voice and audience (tone).

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2.2: Classroom Activity- Identifying and Evaluating the Author's Purpose and Audience

Course Objective: Cultivate students' awareness of purpose and audience when assessing a writing situation; Develop students' abilities in critical thinking, college-level reading, and integrating source material.

SLO-Employ a voice, style, and tone appropriate to the topic selected and the rhetorical situation; Summarize, analyze, and evaluate the arguments, counterarguments, and evidence in the writing of others

Classroom Activity:

Part 1

Students will read the following article from Streetsblog USA titled "How Cities Are Getting Creative to Reclaim Public Space For People." The included hyperlinks in the article, although not required reading, provide additional information on this initiative.

Streetsblog USA. "How Cities Are Getting Creative to Reclaim Public Space for People." *Streetsblog USA*, 3 September 2024, <https://usa.streetsblog.org/2024/09/...ace-for-people>. Accessed 24 November 2024.

How Cities Are Getting Creative To Reclaim Public Space for People

Putting in parks and plazas isn't the only way to reimagine "public spaces" around the needs of people, a new report argues — and if we do it right, these projects can be a powerful tool for equity and health.

"Reclaiming public space" isn't just about turning vacant lots into parks — or bulldozing homes for highways. And in a recent report, the Regional Plan Association of New York's tri-state area argues that the planning profession needs a new approach towards repurposing our land *and* giving residents more "psychological ownership" over their communities.

Check out RPA's recent [case studies](#) of how four U.S. cities are pushing the concept of "reclaiming public space" to new heights, then listen in to our conversation with Vanessa Barrios, the group's director of Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Initiatives to learn more.



The following excerpt has been edited for clarity and length.

Streetsblog: Tell me a little bit about why RPA decided to take a look at this expanded definition of public placemaking for health and equity.

Vanessa Barrios: So the impetus of this report actually comes from about seven years ago when the Regional Plan Association, when we released the Fourth Regional Plan [\[PDF\]](#).

RPA comes out with a regional plan once in a generation; the first one was released in 1929, and it was a response to an influx of immigration into the region. We made many recommendations, such as the location of the George Washington Bridge and the rollout of what our road structures [should] look like.

RPA was very successful — to a fault. A lot of the car dependency that we see today is rooted in some of the recommendations that we made in 1929.

In 2017, when we came up with the fourth plan, we wanted to see it as more of like a values-facing document — [specifically], the values of health, equity, sustainability and prosperity, [which] are the tenets that hold up the plan's 61 recommendations.

We were able to have a huge focus on health because of support from the Robert Wood Johnson Foundation; we released the state of the region's health report in 2016, which showed that there were huge disparities of health in our region. A lot of that has a lot to do with our built environment and the social determinants of health.

Once we finished the fourth regional plan, we proposed to the foundation that we wanted to do another project — one sharing the best practices of what we learned as we created the fourth regional plan. ... We initially wanted to have kind of a peer-to-peer conversation with different planning organizations across the country, [because] we're not completely unique. There are organizations like spur in San Francisco and Metropolitan Planning Council in Chicago, who are nonprofits who do urban planning recommendations, and are not government entities.

What the project evolved into is what we now call the Healthy Regions Planning Exchange. The HRPE consists of 10 regions across the country who come together, both in person at least once a year and online monthly, to talk about the challenges that they are facing as they are working in the planning realm and the government realm, and how they're incorporating health into their work.

Streetsblog: So when you talk about what public space is, one of the things this report argues is that we need to take a more expansive definition of what that – and what it means to *reclaim* public space. So I'm hoping you could just sort of summarize for me: what do most people mean when they say "reclaiming public space" in a planning context, and why do you argue in this report that we need to grow that definition into the kind of case studies that we're going to talk about today?

Barrios: When we think about public space, we think about parks. You ask somebody on Fifth Avenue, "What do you think is public space?" They'll say, "A park," or perhaps, "A public plaza."

But we contend that nearly every area of our public realm could potentially be public space. For example, the farmers markets that we shop in; although [that's] a private entity, people *see* that as a public space where you either encounter folks, where you're able to make connections. It's also an opportunity to access health.

When you think about also the opportunity of public space on our sidewalks — and then oftentimes, the question of safety on our streets and sidewalks — [we need to ask]: what are the things that we're doing as planners that can be interventions [to] facilitate that safety, that access to health, that access to green space that folks who are living in metropolitan areas don't always have access to?

Another example of public space that we delve into in this report is public space in our public transportation systems. Here in New York, the whole concept of safety we oftentimes see in the media [is just about] fear; [it's about the] danger that's on our subways, danger that we can see in our fellow strap hangers.

But this report shows how there's an opportunity to really rethink what safety looks like on our public transportation systems if we implement different models of community safety. That's something that can really build a bridge between: the concept of safety in our public spaces, and in our public transportation systems.

Part 2

After reading the essay, address the following questions in a small group. Refer to specific examples from the article (i.e. paragraphs) to support your answer. Each group should be prepared to share their responses with the class:

1. What is the purpose of the article? To inform? To argue? To persuade? To entertain?
2. Who is the intended audience of the article? Why?
3. How would you describe the tone of the article? Is the tone appropriate or inappropriate given the article's subject matter? Refer to specific lines or paragraphs that illustrate the writer's tone.
4. What kind of language does the writer use to achieve their purpose? Find examples of specific word choices the writer uses.
5. What types of rhetorical appeals (i.e. logos, ethos, pathos) does the writer use to achieve the purpose? Find examples in the article where one or more rhetorical appeals are used.
6. What is your overall opinion of the article based on the author's purpose, audience, tone, and use of rhetorical appeals?

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2.3: Writing Assignment

Course Objective--Cultivate students' awareness of purpose and audience when assessing a writing situation

SLO--Engage in a reflective process of evaluating their own drafts and those of others; Employ a voice, style, and tone appropriate to the topic selected and the rhetorical situation; Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience; Employ rhetorical strategies consistent with the purpose of the writing task.

Activity: Short Writing Assignment

Part 1

Reread and take notes on the article, "[How Cities Are Getting Creative to Reclaim Public Space For People](#)". As you read, consider your own viewpoint and stance on the issues presented by the authors.

Then, write short letter (2 to 3 paragraph) addressed to **one** of the following audiences: your local alderman or mayor based on the following prompt **OR** a neighbor or close friend from your community

Prompt: How would reclaiming public space help or hurt the community you live in?

As you write the letter, consider your audience, tone, and purpose. Think about the community you live in and how the reclaiming of public space would be a benefit or a deterrent to the community's growth. Use at least one example from your own personal experiences and observation to support your claim.

Part 2

After writing the letter, exchange your letter with a classmate. Read the letter, commenting how well the writer communicates their ideas according to the targeted audience.

Assessment Tool

Students in each group should use the following rubric to assess the effectiveness of letter, with a focus on audience and tone:

Criteria	Excellent	Good	Satisfactory	Needs Improvement	Unacceptable
Thesis	Thesis statement is clearly worded, arguable, and focused	For the most part, the thesis state is strong and clear	Thesis statement is somewhat clear and arguable. Some rewording is required to sharpen the focus.	Thesis statement is vaguely worded and unclear	Thesis statement is not arguable. It is more factual or missing
Development of Ideas	Writer provides specific examples from the article and personal experiences that are compelling.	For the most part, the writer provides appropriate details and examples	The writer states unsupported generalizations or unimportant details; more examples from the article and personal experiences/observation are needed to strengthen the claim	The writer offers minimal understanding of the topic with insufficient evidence	Writer does not demonstrate an understanding of the topic.
Style/Language Awareness	Precise, appropriate word choice and tone	For the most part, the writer uses clear language and appropriate word choice	Writer generally uses appropriate word choice	Writer consistently uses inappropriate language, given the writing task.	Writer uses confusing or vague language resulting in a significant disruption of ideas.

Grammar, Spelling, Punctuation	Correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation	With few exceptions, correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation	Writer generally uses correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation but there are one to three serious errors that begin to disrupt the communication of ideas.	Recurring errors in grammar, spelling, and punctuation disrupts the clear expression of ideas.	Excessive errors in grammar, spelling, and punctuation significantly disrupts the clear expression of ideas, making the writing task unreadable in incoherent.
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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Analyzing Visual Arguments on Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

Students will identify and analyze the claim, grounds, warrants, and counterarguments presented in visual arguments (i.e. images, slogans, advertisements, etc.) that related to diversity, equity, and inclusion.

Upon completion of this module, students should be able to:

1. Engage in a recursive process of prewriting, drafting, revising, editing, and proofreading
2. Employ a voice, style, and tone appropriate to the topic selected and the rhetorical situation
3. Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience
4. Establish a clear framework of essay and paragraph organization appropriate to the writing task and the thesis
5. Employ rhetorical strategies consistent with the purpose of the writing task
6. Incorporate reasoning and explanations appropriate to the thesis and its supporting claims

3.1: A Sample Visual Argument Analysis

3.1.1: Annotated Sample Visual Argument Analysis

3.2: Reading to Figure out the Argument

3.2.1: Overview- Reading to Write

3.2.2: Types of Claims to Look out for

3.2.3: Making Notes on the Writer's Claims

3.2.4: Deciding Which Is the Main Claim

3.2.5: Finding the Reasons

3.2.6: Finding the Counterarguments

3.2.7: Finding the Responses to the Counterarguments

3.2.8: Finding the Limits on the Argument

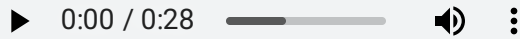
3.3: Analyzing Visual Arguments on Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion--Assignment

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3.1: A Sample Visual Argument Analysis

Media Alternative

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The essay "An Image Is Worth a Thousand Calls to Arms" by Saramanda Swigart analyzes a visual argument.

- [Sample visual argument analysis essay "An Image Is Worth a Thousand Calls to Arms" in PDF with margin notes](#)
- [Sample visual argument analysis essay "An Image Is Worth a Thousand Calls to Arms" accessible version with notes in parentheses](#)

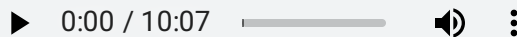
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3.1.1: Annotated Sample Visual Argument Analysis

Media Alternative

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Format note: This version is accessible to screen reader users. Refer to these [tips for reading our annotated sample arguments with a screen reader](#). For a more traditional visual format, see [the PDF version of "An Image Is Worth a Thousand Calls to Arms."](#)

Student Y

English 1C

Prof. Swigart

An Image Is Worth a Thousand Calls to Arms

It may be tempting to think of arguments as being, well, wordy: lengthy essays or speeches designed to make a point and defend it. However, arguments can be entirely or primarily visual. [\[Note: The author introduces visual arguments as an everyday phenomenon that the reader may often encounter without consciously recognizing as arguments.\]](#) Virtually every man-made image is meant to communicate something, and even things so simple and everyday as magazine advertisements or internet banner ads—things we see so often that we often no longer consciously notice—convey the implied argument that we should buy a product, subscribe to a service, or otherwise do what the advertisement wants us to do. The same is nonetheless true of military recruitment posters and ads, which generally share the same common argument: the viewer should join the Armed Forces. [\[Note: This statement narrows the broad topic of visual arguments down to a particular example: military recruitment posters and ads.\]](#)

The entry of the United States into World War I led to a massive recruitment drive for military service as a nation without a large standing army was drawn into an ongoing conflict and forced to rapidly mobilize the population. [\[Note: This paragraph provides historical context for the posters under discussion, focusing the lens on WWI recruitment in the United States.\]](#) Although a draft was issued, making military service for draftees compulsory, there was understandably a vested national interest in recruiting as many volunteers for the armed services as possible. These two recruitment posters below (Figs. 1 and 2), originally printed during World War I and for the United States Army and Navy respectively, use different techniques to appeal to potential recruits' sensibilities and desires. [\[Note: This is the essay's real thesis, citing the Army and Navy posters as using different techniques to appeal to readers. Comparing these techniques is the focus of the essay's body paragraphs.\]](#)



The “I Want YOU for U.S. Army” poster, featuring James Montgomery Flagg's iconic illustration of Uncle Sam, is an image so instantly recognizable that it has become part of the American cultural vocabulary (Fig. 1). [\[Note: The beginning of this body paragraph introduces the name and source for Figure 1.\]](#) Uncle Sam, with his red, white, and blue wardrobe and star-spangled hat, draws on the iconography of the American flag to represent something of the American national spirit. [\[Note: The author describes](#)

the poster's imagery and typography, what the poster denotes. Although depicted as an older man, with longish white beard and hair and bushy white eyebrows, he is depicted as active and authoritative, staring and pointing with one finger at the viewer. Even without the text, it is clear from Uncle Sam's posture and gesture that we, the viewer, are the one being addressed. The text makes the poster's appeal explicit: "I Want YOU for U.S. Army," with the "YOU" highlighted in red text for added emphasis. [Note: The author here shifts into an analysis of what that imagery may mean, or what feelings or ideas it may arouse (what the poster connotes).] The appeal here is primarily one to trust: this character of the national spirit, drawn as an older and paternalistic figure, calls on the viewer directly to go to the "Nearest Recruiting Station." Given that the average Army recruit is bound to be a younger man, this appeal from an older, paternal figure endows the appeal to enlist with an almost filial sense of obligation: if obeying one's father is what a good son does, obeying Uncle Sam is what a good citizen does. Uncle Sam's unsmiling expression signals to the recruit that this appeal to join is a matter of grave importance and urgency, and clearly no laughing matter.



The naval recruitment poster, featuring Richard Fayerweather Babcock's illustration of a sailor riding a torpedo, employs an entirely different aesthetic and makes a radically different appeal to its audience. [Note: The author introduces the name and source of Figure 2, while also emphasizing its contrast with Figure 1.] If the Army recruitment poster invokes a sense of solemn duty, the Navy recruitment poster invokes a sense of adventure. [Note: Here a different pattern is employed: instead of talking about the imagery or type first, the author first describes the feelings aroused by the poster, contrasting these with Figure 1.] Rather than a figure addressing the viewer, we see a sailor riding a torpedo in the manner of a rodeo cowboy riding a bull—even with reins (somewhat inexplicably) in hand. [Note: This passage describes Figure 2's imagery and typography, its content, similar to how the last paragraph described the imagery of Figure 1...] The torpedo, rather than submerged in the water, kicks up spray by the sailor's feet as it skims the water's surface. The sailor's right hand wields a length of rope to act as a crop, showing that he is not a passive passenger on his unlikely steed but in control, whipping it forward, onward. Without context, this image might be confusing as it employs not only an unrealistic depiction of the life of the average sailor but also one that seems as reckless and suicidal as well, riding a bomb. However, the poster's text clarifies its appeal and makes it explicit: "Join the Navy, the Service for Fighting Men." [Note: Here the argument shifts again into an analysis of the emotional appeal being made there.] The characterization of the Navy as the "Service for Fighting Men," combined with the rodeo cowboy imagery, the inherent and obvious danger of riding an (arguably phallic) torpedo qualify the poster's call to wild adventure with a macho, masculine sensibility. Again, given that the average recruit is a young man, these subtle and not-so-subtle appeals to the viewer's masculinity qualify as appeals to the viewer's emotions and self-image. If the Uncle Sam poster gravely calls on dutiful citizens to join the Army, the Navy poster calls on adventurous "Fighting Men." While this poster may have been effective at reaching the audience of its time, it must be noted that audience of a modern Naval recruitment poster has changed. [Note: Unlike the previous paragraph, there is an additional analysis provided of how the appeal of Figure 2's argument has perhaps not aged as well as that of Figure 1.] With the abolition of gender restrictions in the Armed Forces and the re-orientation of recruitment efforts, it's likely that a poster calling on "Fighting Men" to enlist would prove less appealing to a broader audience. Also, the cultural connotation of riding a bomb has itself changed, and would today perhaps be sooner associated with *Dr. Strangelove* and catastrophic self-destruction than a call to adventure.

Analysis of visual arguments can be rewarding and surprising. [Note: The essay returns to the broader subject of visual arguments and how visual elements can enhance, strengthen, or complicate the argument beyond what can be achieved through words alone.] Images can subtly convey a rich and dense amount of information, saying a lot without necessarily saying anything at all. In these examples, most of the message is carried in image alone. Text slogans like "I Want You for U.S. Army" and "Join the Navy" would hardly capture a sense of grave patriotic duty or wild, dangerous adventure without such evocative illustrations to appeal to

patriotism and a collective national identity or a wild adventure on the high seas. The effectiveness and appeal of these posters are enough to show how effective a non-verbal argument can be.

Works Cited

(Note: Works Cited page uses MLA documentation style appropriate for an English class.)

Babcock, Richard Fayerweather, Artist. *Join the Navy, the service for fighting men* / Babcock. Photograph. Retrieved from the Library of Congress, www.loc.gov/item/2002699393/

Flagg, James Montgomery, Artist. *I want you for U.S. Army: nearest recruiting station* / James Montgomery Flagg. Photograph. Retrieved from the Library of Congress, www.loc.gov/item/96507165/

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SECTION OVERVIEW

3.2: Reading to Figure out the Argument

3.2.1: Overview- Reading to Write

3.2.2: Types of Claims to Look out for

3.2.3: Making Notes on the Writer's Claims

3.2.4: Deciding Which Is the Main Claim

3.2.5: Finding the Reasons

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3.2.8: Finding the Limits on the Argument

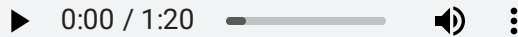
Thumbnail: www.pexels.com/photo/photo-of-woman-holding-pen-3059687/

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3.2.1: Overview- Reading to Write

Media Alternative

Listen to an audio version of this page (1 min, 20 sec):



In almost every college class, we are asked to read someone else's writing, explain what that person is arguing, and point out the strengths and weaknesses of their argument. This chapter offers tools for figuring out the structure of an argument and describing it. In later chapters, we will talk about responding to arguments and analyzing how arguments play on emotion and gain the audience's trust.

So when you are just trying to get the barebones ideas about something you have read straight, how do you go about it? An argument is a swarming cluster of words. How do you get to the heart of it?

In this chapter we look at how to take notes not just on the meaning of each part of the argument but also on its relation to the other parts. Then we use these notes to draw a visual map of an argument. In the map we see the argument's momentum as the reason points us toward the claim. We see how each element implies, supports, limits, or contradicts other elements. Thus, we begin to imagine where the argument is vulnerable and how it might be modified.

In Chapter 3, we'll discuss how to use this logical map to write a summary, and in Chapter 4, we'll see how to follow up the summary with our own opinions.



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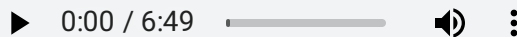
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3.2.2: Types of Claims to Look out for

Media Alternative

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As we make notes on what a writer is claiming at each point, it is worth distinguishing what kind of claim they are making.

Claims of Policy

The most familiar kind of argument demands action. It is easy to see when the writer is asking readers to do something. Here are a few phrases that signal a claim of policy, a claim that is pushing readers to do something:

- We should _____.
- We ought to _____.
- We must _____.
- Let's _____.
- The best course is _____.
- The solution is to _____.
- The next step should be _____.
- We should consider _____.
- Further research should be done to determine _____.

Here are a few sample claims of policy:

- Landlords should not be allowed to raise the rent more than 2% per year.
- The federal government should require a background check before allowing anyone to buy a gun.
- Social media accounts should not be censored in any way.

A claim of policy can also look like a direct command, such as “So if you are an American citizen, don’t let anything stop you from voting.”

Note that not all claims of policy give details or specifics about what should be done or how. Sometimes an author is only trying to build momentum and point us in a certain direction. For example, “Schools must find a way to make bathrooms more private for everyone, not just transgender people.”

Claims of policy don’t have to be about dramatic actions. Even discussion, research, and writing are kinds of action. For example, “Americans need to learn more about other wealthy nations’ health care systems in order to see how much better things could be in America.”



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Claims of Fact

Arguments do not always point toward action. Sometimes writers want us to share their vision of reality on a particular subject. They may want to paint a picture of how something happened, describe a trend, or convince us that something is bad or good.

In some cases, the writer may want to share a particular vision of what something is like, what effects something has, how something is changing, or of how something unfolded in the past. The argument might define a phenomenon, a trend, or a period of history.

Often these claims are simply presented as fact, and an uncritical reader may not see them as arguments at all. However, very often claims of fact are more controversial than they seem. For example, consider the claim, “Caffeine boosts performance.” Does it really? How much? How do we know? Performance at what kind of task? For everyone? Doesn’t it also have downsides? A writer could spend a book convincing us that caffeine really boosts performance and explaining exactly what they mean by those three words.

Some phrases writers might use to introduce a claim of fact include the following:

- Research suggests that _____.
- The data indicate that _____.
- _____ is increasing or decreasing.
- There is a trend toward _____.
- _____ causes _____.
- _____ leads to _____.

Often a claim of fact will be the basis for other claims about what we should do that look more like what we associate with the word “argument.” However, many pieces of writing in websites, magazines, office settings, and academic settings don’t try to move people toward action. They aim primarily at getting readers to agree with their view of what is fact. For example, it took many years of argument, research, and public messaging before most people accepted the claim that “Smoking causes cancer.”

Here are a few arguable sample claims of fact:

- It is easier to grow up biracial in Hawaii than in any other part of the United States.
- Raising the minimum wage will force many small businesses to lay off workers.
- Fires in the western United States have gotten worse primarily because of climate change.
- Antidepressants provide the most benefit when combined with talk therapy.

Claims of Value

In other cases, the writer is not just trying to convince us that something is a certain way or causes something, but is trying to say how good or bad that thing is. They are rating it, trying to get us to share her assessment of its value. Think of a movie or book review or an Amazon or Yelp review. Even a “like” on Facebook or a thumbs up on a text message is a claim of value.

Claims of value are fairly easy to identify. Some phrases that indicate a claim of value include the following:

- _____ is terrible/disappointing/underwhelming.
- _____ is mediocre/average/decent/acceptable.
- We should celebrate _____.
- _____ is great, wonderful, fantastic, impressive, makes a substantial contribution to _____.

A claim of value can also make a comparison. It might assert that something is better than, worse than, or equal to something else. Some phrases that signal a comparative claim of value include these:

- _____ is the best _____.
- _____ is the worst _____.
- _____ is better than _____.
- _____ is worse than _____.
- _____ is just as good as _____.
- _____ is just as bad as _____.

The following are examples of claims of value:

- The Bay Area is the best place to start a biotech career.
- Forest fires are becoming the worst threat to public health in California.
- Human rights are more important than border security.
- Experimenting with drag is the best way I’ve found to explore my feelings about masculinity and femininity.
- It was so rude when that lady asked you what race you are.

Note that the above arguments all include claims of fact but go beyond observing to praise or criticize what they are observing.

Practice Exercise 3.2.2.1

Practice Exercise 3.2.2.2

On a social media site like Facebook or Twitter or on your favorite news site, find an example of one of each kind of claim.

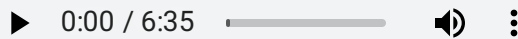
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3.2.3: Making Notes on the Writer's Claims

Media Alternative

Listen to an audio version of this page (6 min, 35 sec):



A first step toward summarizing and responding to an argument is to first make margin notes on the claims. Let's take the following argument as an example:

Sample Argument: "Wouldn't We All Cross the Border?"

All the disagreement over immigration policy I have been hearing about in the news lately reminds me that while I believe in the rule of law, I feel profoundly uncomfortable with the idea of keeping people out who are desperate to come in. Is illegal immigration actually wrong? Is it unethical to cross a border without permission?

I don't have a clear vision yet of what the right border policy would be, and I admit that completely open borders would put our security at risk. But surely there are ways to regulate the border without criminalizing people who are driven by need and good intentions.

If I were raising children in an impoverished third-world community plagued by violence, and if I had a chance to get my family to the U.S., I would take it. I would try to cross a border illegally so my children would get enough to eat and would have a more stable childhood and a chance at a better education and a better career. What parent would sit on their hands and tell themselves, "I want to give my child a better life, but oh well. If I don't have the papers, I guess it would be wrong"?

If most of us, under desperate circumstances, would cross the border without permission and feel no moral qualms about doing so, then we must recognize this crossing as an ethical, reasonable act. If it is ethical and reasonable, then how can either a wall or a detention center be on the side of justice? We must find a policy that treats migrants as we would want to be treated--with empathy, respect, and offers of help.

We can often paraphrase the claims more readily on a second read when we are already familiar with the content. Some need the physicality of taking notes by hand in the margins of a book or a printout.



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Some take notes by creating comments in Word or Google Docs. Others use online annotation systems like Hypothes.is. Another way is to copy the text into a table in a word processing program and write notes in a second column, as we have done below:

Sample Margin Notes on an Argument's Claims

Section of the text	Notes on the claims
Wouldn't We All Cross the Border?	Implies a claim of fact: we would all cross the border (under what circumstances?)
All the disagreement over immigration policy I have been hearing about in the news lately reminds me that while I believe in the rule of law, I feel profoundly uncomfortable with the idea of keeping people out who are desperate to come in. Is illegal immigration actually wrong? Is it unethical to cross a border without permission?	Suggests a claim of value: It might not be wrong to cross illegally. But also suggests another claim of value: that "the rule of law" is right. Is this a contradiction?
I don't have a clear vision yet of what the right border policy would be, and I admit that completely open borders would put our security at risk. But surely there are ways to regulate the border without criminalizing people who are driven by need and good intentions.	Claim of policy about the border--we shouldn't criminalize people who have legitimate reasons to cross. Admits there are security risks in "open borders." Looking for some kind of middle ground that keeps us safe but doesn't criminalize migrants.
If I were raising children in an impoverished third-world community plagued by violence, and if I had a chance to get my family to the U.S., I would take it. I would try to cross a border illegally so my children would get enough to eat and would have a more stable childhood and a chance at a better education and a better career. What parent would sit on their hands and tell themselves, "I want to give my child a better life, but oh well. If I don't have the papers, I guess it would be wrong"?	Claim of fact: the author would consider it right to cross illegally to benefit their children. That is, if their whole family didn't have enough money, a safe place to live, or access to a good education. They imply another claim of fact: that any parent would do the same and feel okay about it.
If most of us, under desperate circumstances, would cross the border without permission and feel no moral qualms about doing so, then we must recognize this crossing as an ethical, reasonable act. If it is ethical and reasonable, then how can either a wall or a detention center be on the side of justice? We must find a policy that treats migrants as we would want to be treated--with empathy, respect, and offers of help.	Starts with the same claim of fact as in the title and the previous paragraph: most people would cross the border illegally. Adds the idea that we wouldn't feel it was wrong. The implication is that if all these people would feel it is right, then it really is "ethical and reasonable." "We must recognize" implies a claim of policy--that people should talk about illegal crossings publicly in a different way than we do now. Claim of policy: Border walls and detention centers are not right. Ends with three policy recommendations for how to treat migrants: empathy, respect, and help.

Notice that attempting to summarize each claim can actually take more space than the original text itself if we are summarizing in detail and trying to be very precise about what the text claims and implies. Of course, we won't want to or need to do this in such detail for every paragraph of every reading we are assigned to write about. We can resort to it when the argument gets harder to follow or when it's especially important to be precise.

Practice Exercise 3.2.3.1

Make notes in your own words on the claims of fact, value, and policy you find in an argument you are reading for class or one of our [suggested readings](#). Make a table with two columns and paste the argument into the first column. In the second column, summarize the points the author makes as in the example above. If you like, you can make a copy of this [Google Docs notes template](#).

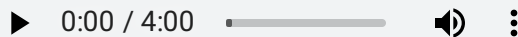
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3.2.4: Deciding Which Is the Main Claim

Media Alternative

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Now that we have this list of claims in the margin of the text, we know some of the things that the author wants us to believe. How do we sort them and put them in relation to each other? In this case, we found claims of policy, fact, and value, some of which were repeated in different parts of the argument. Which claim is the main point? How do other claims support this one?



Which direction is the author taking the argument?
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We can try asking ourselves the following questions to see if we already have a sense of what the argument's goal is.

- What does the writer want us to believe?
- What does the writer most want to convince us of?
- Where is the writer going with this?
- If the writer had to make their point in just one sentence, what would they say?

A good first place to look for the focus, of course, is the title. Often the title will declare the main claim outright. Here, the title question "Wouldn't We All Cross the Border?" implies the answer "Yes." We can look for the same idea in the text and check whether it seems to be the main one. The third paragraph describes why the author would cross the border and then generalizes to claim that others would do the same. At the start of the last paragraph, the writer declares that " ...most of us, under desperate circumstances, would cross the border without permission and feel no moral qualms about doing so." Note that this is a claim of fact about what people would do and how they would feel about it.

But is this the main claim? When we review the other sections, we find several other claims of policy. Introductions set expectations, and here, the first paragraph alludes to public debates on immigration policy. It suggests that it may not be right to stop people from coming into America, and it may not be wrong to cross the border, even illegally. These early references to what is right suggest that the argument aims to do more than describe how people might feel under different circumstances. The argument is going to weigh in on what border policy should be. The second paragraph confirms this sense as it builds up to the still vague sentence, " Surely there are ways to regulate the border without criminalizing people who are driven by need and good intentions."

In the last paragraph, we learn what these ways might involve. Three different claims of policy emerge:

1. "... We must recognize this crossing as an ethical, reasonable act."
2. "How can either a wall or a detention center be on the side of justice?" (The implication, of course, is that they cannot be.)
3. " We must find a policy that treats migrants as we would want to be treated--with empathy, respect, and offers of help."

Which of these final claims is the overall focus? Arguments sometimes emphasize their main point in the very last sentence, in part to make it memorable. However, the end of the argument can also be a place for the author to go a little beyond their main point

and suggest issues for further thought. The phrase "empathy, respect, and offers of help" sounds important, but we should note that the rest of the argument isn't about how to help migrants. However, the idea that we should respond more positively to migrants has recurred throughout. The idea that migrants are not in the wrong--that they are not criminals--is clearly key, and so is the idea that we should change border policy accordingly.

Here is one way, then, to combine those last two ideas into a summary of the overall claim of the argument:

Claim: Border policy should not criminalize undocumented immigrants.

Practice Exercise 3.2.4.1

Choose an argument you are reading for class or one of [our suggested readings](#), read it closely, and then try to summarize the main claim in your own words. If you are unsure, return to [making notes on the writer's claims](#) and then reflect on the questions above.

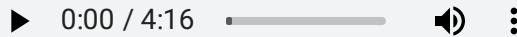
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3.2.5: Finding the Reasons

Media Alternative

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Once we know what the main point of the reading is, we can ask ourselves what reasons the author gives. We can go through our annotations to look at the other claims and see how some may be used as reasons for the main claim or as reasons for one of the reasons.

We can write the claims in a map and use the arrows to show which claim works as a reason supporting which other claim. Each claim moves our mind from one idea to the next in the direction the writer wants it to go. The claim farthest to the right, the one that the others point toward, is the main point. Such maps might take a few different forms, such as these:

Reason → Claim

Reason A → Reason B → Claim

Reason A → Claim

Reason B ↗

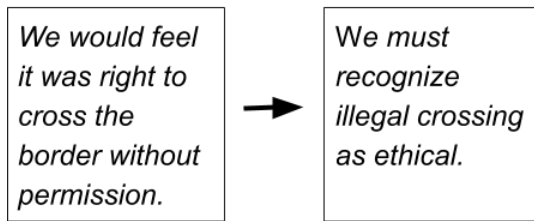
How can we tell where to put each claim on the map and where to point the arrows? It can help to remember that particular words and phrases in academic and professional writing basically act as arrows. They signal that one idea is supposed to lead to another. Here are some such phrases:

- Because _____, _____.
- Because of this, _____.
- If _____, then _____.
- Since _____, _____.
- For this reason, _____.
- We can conclude _____.
- Therefore, _____.
- So _____.
- Consequently, _____.
- As a result, _____.
- Hence _____.
- Thus _____.
- It follows that _____.

For example, in the above argument, “If _____, then _____.” connects two claims in the following sentence:

“If most of us, under desperate circumstances, would cross the border without permission and feel no moral qualms about doing so, then we must recognize this crossing as an ethical, reasonable act.”

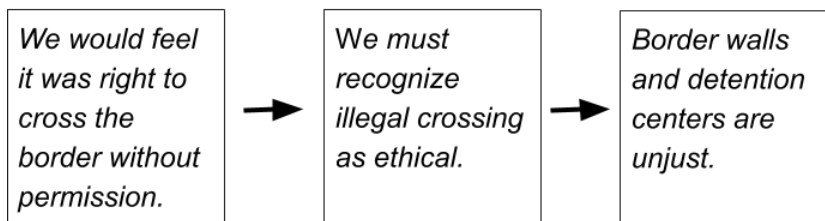
We could write a short version of the first half of the sentence, put it in a box, and point it toward a short version of the second half:



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See the [accessible text description of this one-reason map](#).

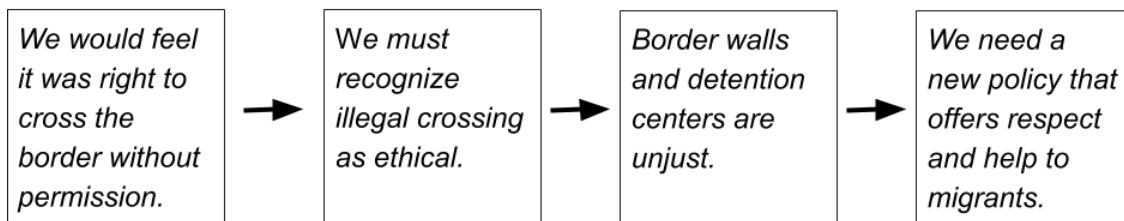
The following sentence sets up another If _____, then _____ statement: "If it is ethical and reasonable, then how can either a wall or a detention center be on the side of justice?"

We could add this on thus:



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See the [accessible text description of this two-reason map](#).

If border walls and detention centers are unjust, there must be a need for an alternate approach. The next sentence claims, "We must find a policy that treats migrants as we would want to be treated--with empathy, respect, and offers of help." We can offer a short version of this sentence as the final implication.



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See the [accessible text description of this three-reason map](#).

Practice Exercise 3.2.5.1

1. Choose an argument you are reading for class or one of [our suggested readings](#). You may want to focus on a short excerpt of one or more paragraphs.
2. Read your text closely and identify any reasons given to support the main claim and any reasons for those reasons.
3. Then map out the author's reasons as in the examples above. Describe each reason in your own words. You can handwrite your map or copy this [Google Drawings template](#) and insert the reasons. Later, you will add other elements of the argument to the map.

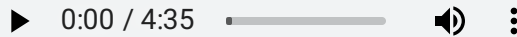
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3.2.6: Finding the Counterarguments

Media Alternative

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Very often, as we read an argument we will find not just what the author thinks and believes, but the author's description of other people's opposing arguments as well. An argument is part of an ongoing broader conversation about the subject, and the writer can remind us of what they are responding to. So as we read we can look for and mark these counterarguments.

In a complex text it can be easy to miss that a particular point is actually not one that the writer agrees with--they may be bringing it up in order to shoot it down. We can look out for particular phrases that are often used in academic writing to signal that the writer is switching sides temporarily and describing an idea that goes against the argument.



In chess, it's easy to tell which piece is on which side, but in a text we need other clues.
Image by [Агзам Гайсин](#) from [Pixabay](#) under the [Pixabay License](#).

Very often the way the author will both signal to us that they are introducing the counterargument and signal their attitude toward it. They will convey the degree to which they disagree and the respect or contempt they feel for this opposing view.

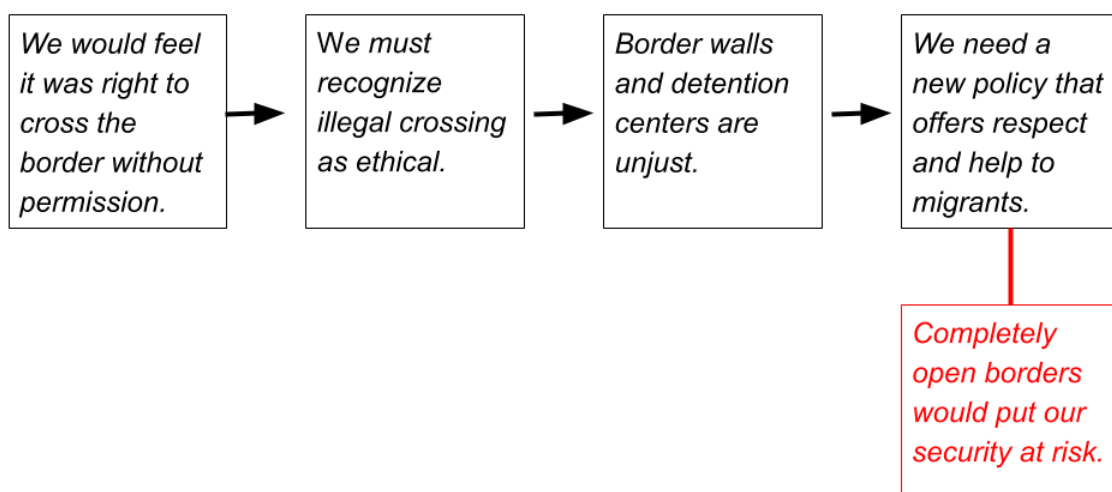
Common Phrases That Introduce Counterarguments

Attitude to the Counterargument	Phrases
Negative The writer thinks the counterargument is completely wrong.	- It is a popular misconception that_____. - Some have fallen for the idea that_____. - Many people mistakenly believe that_____.

Attitude to the Counterargument	Phrases
Neutral The writer is about to describe a counterargument without giving their opinion yet.	• Many people think _____. • Some, on the other hand, will argue that _____. • Some might disagree, claiming that _____. • Of course, many have claimed that _____. • Some will take issue with _____, arguing that _____. • Some will object that _____. • Some will dispute the idea that _____, claiming that _____. • One criticism of this way of thinking is that _____. Note that these neutral examples don't tell us whether the writer thinks the counterargument has any validity. Usually, the writer will want to follow them with a sentence that does reveal their opinion.
Positive The writer sees some merit in the counterargument. They agree with it even though it hurts their argument. This is called concession .	• It is true that _____. • I do concede _____. • We should grant that _____. • We must admit that _____. • I acknowledge that _____. • X has a point that _____. • Admittedly, _____. • Of course, _____. • To be sure, _____. • There may be something to the idea that _____.

In the border argument example, the writer never directly mentions other writers who disagree. Instead, they signal with the phrase "I admit" that they are going to summarize a valid point which goes against their own main argument: "I admit that completely open borders would put our security at risk."

We could add this to our map as follows, with the counterargument in red to show it goes against the rest of the argument:



"Argument Map with Counterargument" by Anna Mills is licensed [CC BY-NC 4.0](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc/4.0/).
 See the [accessible text description of the argument map with counterargument](#).

Practice Exercise 3.2.6.1

1. Choose an argument you are reading for class or one of [our suggested readings](#). You may want to focus on a short excerpt of one or more paragraphs.
2. Read your text closely and identify any counterarguments it mentions. What is the writer's attitude to each counterargument?
3. Describe each counterargument in your own words and add it to your argument map. You can handwrite your map or copy this [Google Drawings template](#).

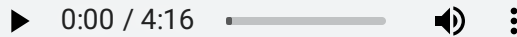
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3.2.7: Finding the Responses to the Counterarguments

Media Alternative

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After a writer summarizes another perspective, they will signal that they are switching back to their own perspective. If they have not already given a hint about their attitude to the other side, they will have to make their response clear now. Do they see the counterargument as completely wrong-headed, or as having some merit?

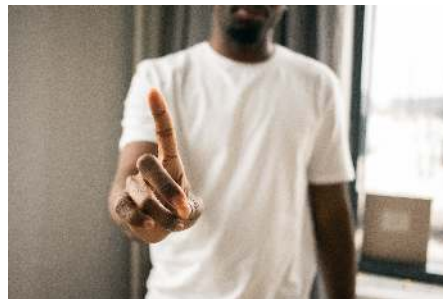


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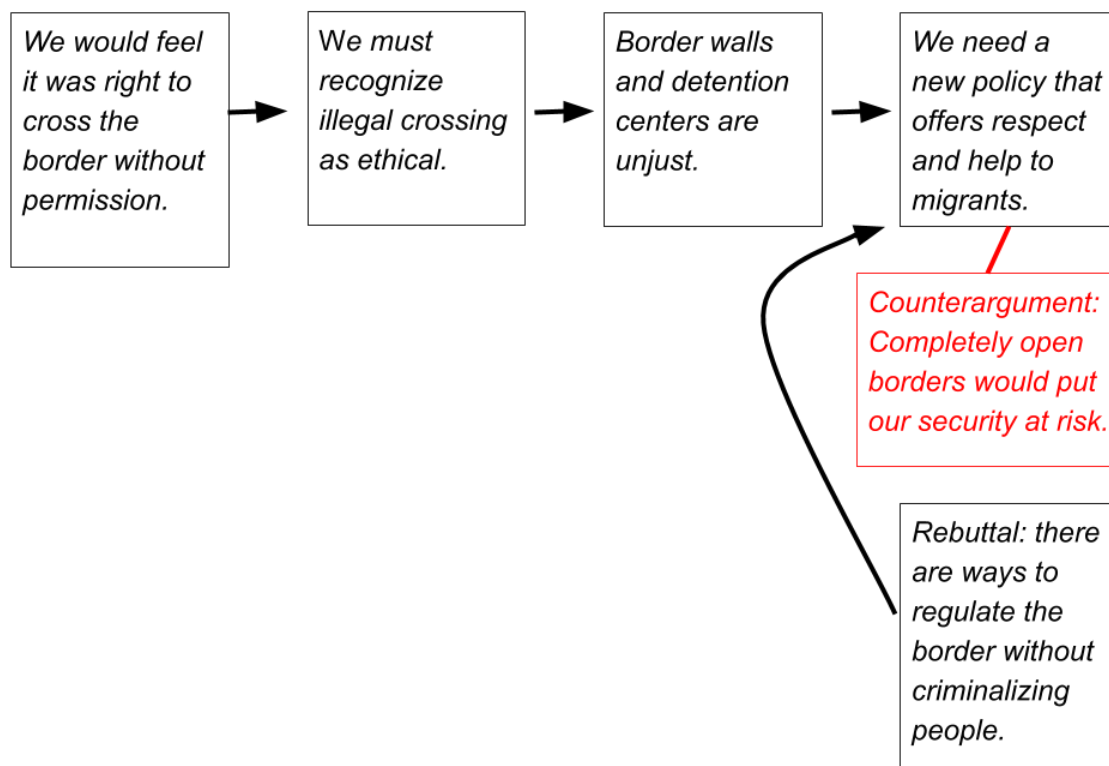
If the writer completely disagrees with the counterargument, they will follow up their description of it by pointing out its flaws. This direct rebuttal will bring the readers back to the writer's side. If they have just conceded a point, they will now emphasize the reason why their own argument still holds. The more the writer has credited the counterargument, the more they will need to explain why readers shouldn't accept it, at least not completely. Below are some phrases which can point toward the problem or limitation of the counterargument.

Common Phrases for Responding to Counterarguments

Attitude to the Counterargument	Phrases
If the writer considers the counterargument totally wrong	• This idea misses the fact that _____. • I disagree because _____. • This depends on the assumption that _____ which is incorrect because _____. • This argument overlooks _____. • This argument contradicts itself _____. • This is mistaken because _____.

Attitude to the Counterargument	Phrases
If the writer partly agrees with the counterargument	• It is true that _____, but _____. • I do concede _____, and yet _____. • We should grant that _____, but we must still acknowledge that _____. • We can admit that _____ and still believe that _____. • I acknowledge that _____, and yet we should nevertheless recognize that _____. • Critics have a point that _____; however it is more important that we focus on _____. • Admittedly, _____. However, _____. • Of course, _____, but I still insist that _____. • To be sure, _____; but _____. • There may be something to the idea that _____, and yet _____.

In the border argument example, the writer concedes that the counterargument does have merit: "I admit that completely open borders would put our security at risk." Immediately, the writer responds, "But surely there are ways to regulate the border without criminalizing people who are driven by need and good intentions." The word "but" signals the transition from concession back to the writer's own side. In the map, we can put the rebuttal below the counterargument and use the arrow to show it supporting the main claim.



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See the [accessible text description of the argument map with counterargument and rebuttal](#).

Practice Exercise 3.2.7.1

1. Choose an argument you are reading for class or one of our suggested readings. You may want to focus on a short excerpt of one or more paragraphs.
2. Read your text closely and identify any counterarguments it mentions. What is the writer's attitude to each counterargument?
3. Decide what your attitude to this counterargument is. Choose a phrase from the above table to introduce the counterargument.

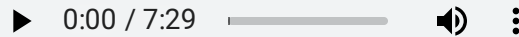
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3.2.8: Finding the Limits on the Argument

Media Alternative

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If we are getting ready to summarize and respond to an argument, we need to notice exactly how the writer has qualified or limited what they are saying.

Often if a counterargument has some merit, a writer may respond acknowledging that, taking a step back and limiting what they are claiming. They might make an exception for a particular case where they realize their initial claim wouldn't hold. Or they might clarify that their claim only applies to a particular group or situation.



Just as we might limit a tomato harvest to ripe tomatoes, we might want to limit an argument to certain cases and not others.
Photo by [Roon Z](#) on [Pexels](#) under the [Pexels License](#).

Faced with a powerful counterargument, a writer might also admit a certain degree of uncertainty about their claim as a whole. They might consider the argument worth putting forward for consideration even if they are not sure it is right.

Common Phrases Used to Limit Arguments

Kinds of limitations on arguments	Phrases
Expressing less than perfect certainty	- Perhaps, _____. - It is worth considering the idea that _____. _____ may _____. _____ might _____. _____ could possibly _____. - Probably, _____. - Very likely, _____. - Almost certainly, _____.

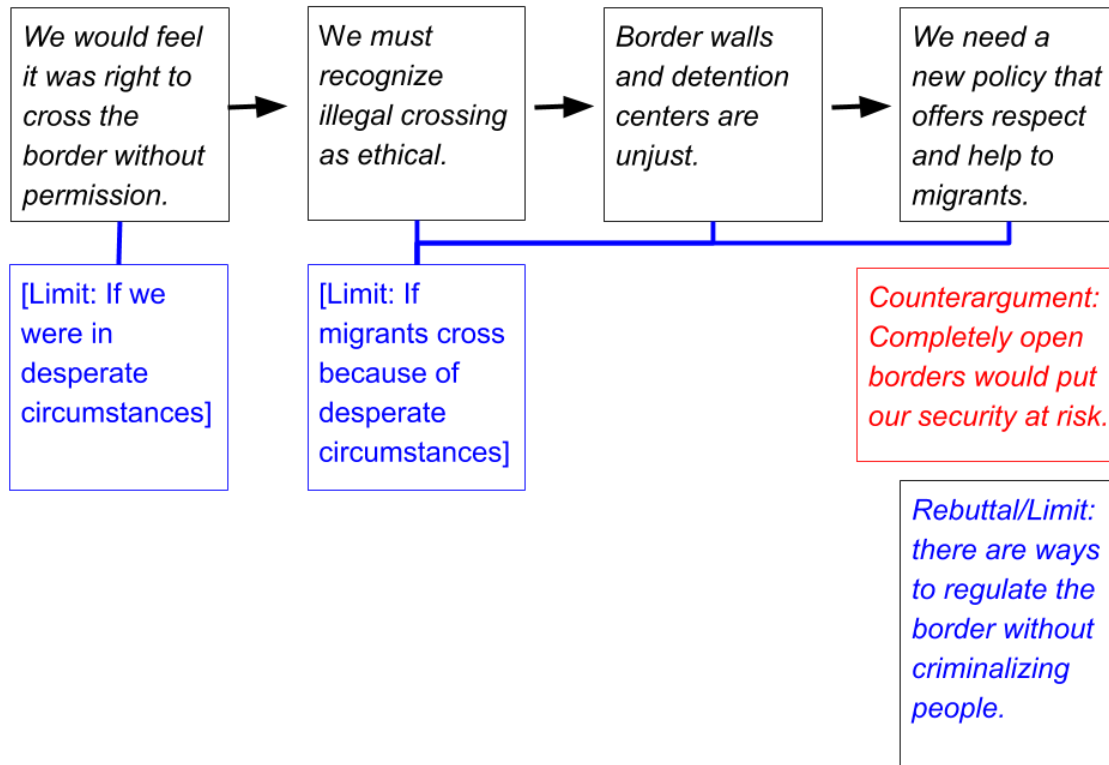
Kinds of limitations on arguments	Phrases
Limiting what the argument is claiming or restricting the scope of the argument	- Few _____. - In a few cases, _____. - Some _____. - Many _____. - Most _____. - The vast majority of _____. - Almost all _____. _____ unless _____. - If it is not the case that _____, then _____. _____, except in the case that _____. - We can exclude cases where _____.

When we read arguments, we can watch for these limitations and add them to our argument map. In the case of the border argument, limitations are found throughout. We have highlighted them and commented on them below.

Sample Notes on an Argument's Limits

Argument	Notes
Title: Wouldn't We All Cross the Border?	Not limited at all--a universal "all"
All the disagreement over immigration policy I have been hearing about in the news lately reminds me that while I believe in the rule of law, I feel profoundly uncomfortable with the idea of keeping people out who are desperate to come in. Is illegal immigration actually wrong? Is it unethical to cross a border without permission?	Limits the group of immigrants we are talking about to those who are desperate. This is an argument about refugees of one kind or another, not about people who just feel they would be happier or more successful in the U.S. So maybe the author would still consider it fine to criminalize those who cross illegally because they prefer to live in the U.S. if they are not currently in dire straits.
I don't have a clear vision yet of what the right border policy would be, and I admit that completely open borders would put our security at risk. But surely there are ways to regulate the border without criminalizing people who are driven by need and good intentions.	Clarifies that some "regulation" of borders is okay. Their argument does not condemn all efforts to establish rules and consequences at the border. Again, this clarifies that this only applies to migrants with a compelling reason to cross.
If I were raising children in an impoverished third-world community plagued by violence, and if I had a chance to get my family to the U.S., I would take it. I would try to cross a border illegally so my children would get enough to eat and would have a more stable childhood and a chance at a better education and a better career. What parent would sit on their hands and tell themselves, "I want to give my child a better life, but oh well. If I don't have the papers, I guess it would be wrong"?	Outlines a specific circumstance that would justify crossing illegally, implying that other circumstances might not justify it.
If most of us, under desperate circumstances, would cross the border without permission and feel no moral qualms about doing so, then we must recognize this crossing as an ethical, reasonable act. If it is ethical and reasonable, then how can either a wall or a detention center be on the side of justice? We must find a policy that treats migrants as we would want to be treated--with empathy, respect, and offers of help.	Repeats the limitation to migrants who are desperate. Note: The final sentences don't mention any limitation on which migrants we are talking about.

The main limitation, then, can be entered into the argument map in blue and in brackets thus:



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See the [accessible text description of the argument map with limits](#).

Now that we have analyzed the parts of the argument and their relations to each other, we are ready for the next step demanded by most college writing assignments. Chapter 3 will discuss how to write a clear and precise summary of an argument.

Practice Exercise 3.2.8.2

1. Choose an argument you are reading for class or one of our suggested readings. You may want to focus on a short excerpt of one or more paragraphs.
2. Read your text closely and identify any limits it puts on any of its claims.
3. Describe each limit in your own words and add it to your argument map. You can [handwrite your map](#) or copy this [Google Drawings template](#).

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3.3: Analyzing Visual Arguments on Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion--Assignment

Course Objectives--Develop students' writing process in composing formal, college-level essays using various rhetorical writing modes; Cultivate students' awareness of purpose and audience when assessing a writing situation; Develop students' abilities in critical thinking, college-level reading, and integrating source material.

SLO--Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience; Summarize, analyze, and evaluate the arguments, counterarguments, and evidence in the writing of others

Writing Task: select a visual image that focuses on a diversity, equity, or inclusion issue and prepare an analysis identifying and discussing the effectiveness of the image's argument.

Step 1: select your visual image with a DEI focus. You may find an appropriate image from a recent local newspaper or magazine. You may also use Google's search engine to find an image, using key terms such as "diversity," "equity," or "inclusion" as part of the search parameters (or you can use suggested topics listed below).

Or, you use some of the following topics as search terms to find an image:

Racial inequality

Affirmative action and college admissions

Workplace disabilities

Gender identity

Same-sex marriage

Classism

Prejudice

Step 2: after selecting your image, begin to analyze the picture. Your analysis should consider the following and you should take notes for each question prior to writing your paper:

1). What argument (claim) does the image present?

2) Who is the audience?

3) Is the image a single frame or a series of sequential frames? If the latter, how does the argument evolve over the series? How do elements like color choices, layout, and style influence the audience?

4). Consider the choices of imagery and content. Are the drawings realistic or caricatures? Are there references to past or current events or ideas? How do the words and images work together to present an argument?

5) What is the tone in the image? Serious? Humorous? Does the choice of tone impact the audience?

6) Identify the rhetorical appeals (logos, ethos, pathos) in the image. How effective are the appeals in strengthening or weakening the argument?

7) Does the image implicitly or explicitly refer to any actual people or events? Does the cultural relevance function as a strategy to making the argument?

8) Identify the counterarguments. How does the image refute the opposition's point of view?

Step 3: begin drafting the analysis. The analysis should be 5 to 6 typed double-spaced pages. You should be prepared to write more than one draft.

Assessment Tool:

Criteria	Excellent	Good	Satisfactory	Needs Improvement	Unacceptable

Introduction/Thesis Statement	Exceptionally clear, strong, well-written intro that captures the reader's interest. Thesis statement is clearly worded, arguable, and focused.	Introduction captures the reader's interest and provides an overview of the topic. Thesis statement is strong and clear	Adequate introductory paragraph that announces the paper's focus Thesis statement is somewhat clear and arguable but requires rewording to sharpen the focus	Weak introductory paragraph that does not clearly announce the paper's focus Thesis statement is vaguely worded and unclear	Introductory paragraph is missing or is not focused on a specific topic (too broad or multiple topics) Thesis statement is not arguable, too factual, or missing
Organization/Development of Ideas	All main points are exceptionally well-developed in five or more pages of text Writer provides specific, effective textual examples Writer demonstrates a thorough, logical, insightful analysis of the image. Clear transition usage between all paragraphs	Main points are well-developed in five pages of text minimum Writer provides some appropriate details and examples Writer demonstrates a logical analysis of the image which includes some insight Effective transition usage between most paragraphs	Main points are fairly well-explained though additional textual evidence is needed to strengthen the analysis Writer occasionally states unsupported generalizations or unimportant details Writer demonstrates a basic understanding of the topic with limited insight Most ideas are signaled by paragraph divisions and transition usage	Lack of consistent paragraph usage indicates writer's inability to effectively organize ideas Several main points are not adequately developed Writer frequently uses irrelevant or redundant ideas Writer offers minimal understanding of the topic with insufficient insight Infrequent usage of transitions	Writer fails to explain all main points; the relationship between ideas is unclear, undeveloped, or vague Writer does not demonstrate an understanding of the topic No transition usage

Style/Language Awareness	Precise, appropriate word choice	Writer uses clear language and usually appropriate word choice	Writer uses generally appropriate vocabulary	Writer consistently uses inappropriate language, given the assignment's context	Writer uses confused and/or vague language resulting in an unreadable essay
	Writer's style illustrates strong control of sentence structure	Essay illustrates writer's good control of sentence structure	Essay illustrates simple and/or complex sentences with few errors in syntax usages	Significant problems with sentence structure results in an unclear expression of ideas	Tangled or unclear sentence structure

Grammar, Spelling, and Punctuation	Correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation	With few exceptions, correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation	Usually correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation	Recurrent grammar and/or punctuation concerns (run- ons, fragments, comma splices, subject-verb agreement, verb form errors) that disrupts the expression of ideas	Excessive and/or disruptive errors in grammar, spelling, and punctuation results in an unclear expression of ideas —the essay is unreadable
	1 or 2 typos or careless errors	3 to 4 typos or careless errors	5 to 7 typos or careless errors	Recurrent misspellings	Writer fails to proofread the essay (11 or more typos or careless errors)
Conclusion	Excellent summary of topic with no introduction of new information	Conclusion is clear, strong, and provides a summation of the topic	One to three serious errors (run-ons, fragments, comma splices, subject-verb agreement, verb form concerns)	Pattern of typos or careless errors (8 to 10)	Writer fails to provide a conclusion
	Writer concludes the analysis on a strong note	Answers the “so what?” question	To some extent, the conclusion brings closure to the essay	The conclusion is incomplete or does not answer the “so what?” question	The essay ends abruptly
			A more forceful ending is required		The writer introduces one or more new topics

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Writing Argumentative Thesis Statements

SLO-Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience; Establish a clear framework of essay and paragraph organization appropriate to the writing tasks and the thesis.

Intro: in this module, students will review the components of effective thesis statement writing in preparation for stating a clear, focused stance on a debatable issue in a written essay. This will include examining and critiquing examples of thesis statements and an opportunity to practice writing an argumentative thesis statement.

[4.1: Reading- Argumentative Thesis Statements](#)

[4.2: Classroom Activity- Reviewing and Evaluating Thesis Statements](#)

[4.3: Thesis Statement Writing and Critique Assignment](#)

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4.1: Reading- Argumentative Thesis Statements

Read: the following text from Excelsior OWL (CC BY) provides an overview to thesis writing.

SLO: Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience; Establish a clear framework of essay and paragraph organization appropriate to the writing task and the thesis.

Argumentative Thesis



As explained in [Research](#), not all essays will require an explicitly stated thesis, but most argumentative essays will. Instead of implying your thesis or main idea, in an argumentative essay, you'll most likely be required to write out your thesis statement for your audience. A thesis statement is a one- to two-sentence statement that presents the main idea and makes an assertion about your issue. You may have a longer thesis for much longer essays, but one to two sentences is a good general guideline. And, remember, in an argumentative essay, the assertion you present in your thesis is going to be particularly important.

When you make your assertion in your thesis, it should be clear and direct. You want your audience to have no doubt about your point. Of course, how assertive you are in your thesis and the content you choose to include depends upon the type of argumentative essay you are writing. For example, in a [Classical or Aristotelian](#) argument (explained in pages that follow), your thesis statement should clearly present your side of the issue. In a [Rogerian argument](#) (explained in pages that follow), your thesis should bring both sides of the issue together.

Still, there are some basic guidelines to keep in mind when it comes to an argumentative thesis statement.

- Your thesis statement should be **one to two sentences**.
- Your thesis statement should **clearly present the main idea of your essay and make some kind of assertion** (even if that assertion is about bringing two sides together).
- Your thesis **should not make an “announcement”** about what your essay will cover. Instead, it should just present your assertion. For example, a thesis like this makes an announcement:

In this paper, I will persuade you to vote for candidates who support education reform.

Instead you might write:

Because our education system is in need of reform, we should vote for candidates who are willing to make the necessary changes.

- While there is no such thing as a “required” place for your thesis statement, most academic essays will present the thesis statement early on, usually **near the end of the introduction**. There is a reason for this. Audience members are more likely to understand and absorb each point as readers if you have told them, in advance, what they should be getting out of your essay. Still, you should check with your professor if you would like to present your thesis somewhere else, such as at the end of your essay.
- **Your thesis statement is the most important sentence in your essay.** It’s your chance to make sure your audience really understands your point. Be sure your assertion and your writing style are clear.

Access original content in the link below:

<https://owl.excelsior.edu/argument-a...tative-thesis/>

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4.2: Classroom Activity- Reviewing and Evaluating Thesis Statements

Classroom Activity:

SLO: Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience; Establish a clear framework of essay and paragraph organization appropriate to the writing task and the thesis

Students will review, evaluate, and discuss their answers to the following thesis statements from Excelsior OWL (CC-BY):

<https://lumenlearning.h5p.com/conten...21810808/embed>

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4.3: Thesis Statement Writing and Critique Assignment

Course Objective: Enhance students' abilities in organizing, developing, and revising their essays

SLO--Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience; Establish a clear framework of essay and paragraph organization appropriate to the writing task and the thesis; Revise work to enhance coherence and clarity while communicating with relevant discourse communities.

Activity: Part 1

The following topics are related to issues of diversity, equity, and inclusion. For each topic, write a one sentence arguable thesis statement. You should review your notes from the previous reading and activity. You should also keep in mind the thesis statement you will draft could be used for a short, argumentative paper (5 to 6 typed, double spaces pages). As such, make sure to keep the thesis focused. You may want to brainstorm ideas on where you stand on listed issues on a sheet of paper first.

Write a thesis statement for all of the following topics:

Migrant housing crisis in Chicago

Wheel chair accessible El Train platforms

Food deserts in your local community

The homeless using local parks as shelters

Race as a determining factor in college admissions

Assuming that people whose native language is not English are not capable of speaking English

Activity: Part 2

Working in groups of 2 or 3, exchange drafts of the working thesis statement you completed in Part 1. For each thesis statement, evaluate its effectiveness, using the following rubric and scores. Write suggestions for improvement on for each reviewed thesis statement as appropriate:

Assessment Tool

Excellent (4 pts)	Good (3 pts)	Satisfactory (2 pts)	Needs More Work (1 pts)	Unacceptable (0 pts)
Thesis statement is clearly worded, arguable, and focused.	Thesis statement is strong and mostly clear.	Thesis statement is somewhat clear and arguable but requires more rewording to sharpen the focus.	The writer uses vague, broad, and unclear wording making the stance unclear to the reader.	The thesis statement is fact and not arguable.



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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

5: Writing Counterarguments

[5.1: Classroom Activity](#)

[5.2: Reading About Counterarguments](#)

[5.3: Writing Assignment](#)

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5.1: Classroom Activity

Classroom Activity:

SLO: Summarize, analyze, and evaluate the arguments, counterarguments, and evidence in the writing of others.

Part 1

First, students will read and annotate the following article, "Food Deserts Are Environmental Racism At Work" by Oliva Aly.

Food Deserts are Environmental Racism at work



As the Black Lives Matter movement has picked up speed and force in the last couple weeks, activists are highlighting ways in which people of color are subject to the impacts of centuries of systematic racism that left African Americans and other people of color at a disadvantage. One of the lesser known ways in which people of color are disadvantaged is [environmental racism](#), defined as: “the disproportionate impact of environmental hazards on people of color.” Environmental racism can take the form of lower quality of air and drinking water, as well as what are known as food deserts. According to the [Food Empowerment Project](#), food deserts are: “geographic areas where residents access to affordable, healthy food options (especially fresh fruits and vegetables) is restricted or nonexistent due to the absence of grocery stores within convenient traveling distance.” For example, a study by the Economic Research Service of the US Department of Agriculture revealed that about 2.3 million people (2.2% of all US households) live more than one mile away from a supermarket and do not own a car.

Food deserts are a problem that primarily affects black and brown residents who live in low-income neighborhoods. Studies have shown that wealthy neighborhoods have at least three times more supermarkets than that of low-income neighborhoods, and that white neighborhoods have at least four times as many grocery stores as predominantly black neighborhoods; as well, grocery stores in predominantly black neighborhoods usually have a much smaller selection. Further, people's choices of food to buy to feed their families is limited by what they can afford, which is compounded by the abundance of fast food restaurants in areas of food deserts.

Lack of access to affordable and nutritious food is linked to several debilitating health issues, primarily [type 2 diabetes](#); food deserts have been linked to higher rates of diabetes, hypertension, heart disease and [stroke](#). Food insecurity not only increases one's risk for Type 2 Diabetes, but managing Type 2 Diabetes is much harder with limited access to nutritious foods that can help one manage their blood sugar, cholesterol, and blood pressure. Speaking about the presence of food deserts in predominantly African-American neighborhoods in Chicago, pediatrician [Madeleine Shalowitz](#) explains, "(Type 2) diabetes may not require medicine but it does require lifestyle management with regards to diet and exercise... in a food desert, things like healthy fruits and vegetables, a balance of whole grains and protein are difficult to get."

While there are small, local solutions to food insecurity, these solutions are only band-aids that can temporarily bring nutritious foods into areas of food deserts, but long-term fixes have evaded struggling low-income neighborhoods. Some neighborhoods have created local food co-op programs to simultaneously ease food insecurity and create jobs for residents, but many co-op programs have failed due to lack of revenue. Some cities have also begun mobile farmers markets or what are known as bus-stop farmers markets (markets that are located conveniently on public transportation routes), but many have not been able to achieve long lasting success. One of the more successful solutions has been community gardens, such as [DC Urban Greens](#), that provide free or low-cost produce to those in need. Community gardens are managed by local residents, and teach residents about growing their own food and how to cook easy, low-cost meals that utilize produce grown in the gardens. And while community gardens are beneficial for neighborhoods in a myriad of ways, it is difficult, if not impossible, to reach all those in need, and receiving produce can be particularly difficult in times like the COVID-19 pandemic.

As well, there are many government subsidized programs that work to help low-income residents afford fresh and nutritious foods. SNAP (Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program) is a USDA program that helps low-income residents purchase food-distributed in New York with an Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) card. In 2008, the NYC Human Resources Administration and the NYC Department of Health and Mental Hygiene partnered with Greenmarket to create Health Bucks: coupons distributed to SNAP recipients to incentivize shopping at local markets. While both local and government based programs *help*, it does not change the fact that a disturbing number of Americans live without convenient access to nutritious food.

Access original content in the link below:

<https://www.thinkzerollc.com/post/fo...racism-at-work>

Part 2

After reading and annotating the article, on a sheet of paper, create a table using the following example and list the arguments, the counterargument for each argument that you find, and list any counterarguments not considered by the author:

Writer's Thesis Statement:

Arguments	Counterarguments	List other counterarguments not considered by the author

Part 3

After completing the chart, work in groups of 2 to 3 students and discuss the findings and how the arguments and counterarguments support the writer's thesis.

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5.2: Reading About Counterarguments

Read: For information on how to write counterarguments and their importance in argumentative writing, read the following texts from OER Commons (CC BY NC SA) and The University of Arizona Global Campus (CC BY)

SLO-Summarize, analyze, and evaluate the arguments, counterarguments, and evidence in the writing of others.

Acknowledging Opposing Ideas and Limits to Your Argument

Because an argument implies differing points of view on the subject, you must be sure to acknowledge those opposing ideas. Avoiding ideas that conflict with your own gives the reader the impression that you may be uncertain, fearful, or unaware of opposing ideas. Thus it is essential that you not only address counterarguments but also do so respectfully.

Try to address opposing arguments earlier rather than later in your essay. Rhetorically speaking, ordering your positive arguments last allows you to better address ideas that conflict with your own, so you can spend the rest of the essay countering those arguments. This way, you leave your reader thinking about your argument rather than someone else's. You have the last word.

Acknowledging points of view different from your own also has the effect of fostering more credibility between you and the audience. They know from the outset that you are aware of opposing ideas and that you are not afraid to give them space.

It is also helpful to establish the limits of your argument and what you are trying to accomplish. In effect, you are conceding early on that your argument is not the ultimate authority on a given topic. Such humility can go a long way toward earning credibility and trust with an audience. Audience members will know from the beginning that you are a reasonable writer, and audience members will trust your argument as a result. For example, in the following concessionary statement, the writer advocates for stricter gun control laws, but she admits it will not solve all of our problems with crime:

Although tougher gun control laws are a powerful first step in decreasing violence in our streets, such legislation alone cannot end these problems since guns are not the only problem we face.

Such a concession will be welcome by those who might disagree with this writer's argument in the first place. To effectively persuade their readers, writers need to be modest in their goals and humble in their approach to get readers to listen to the ideas.

Text above adapted from: [Writing for Success – Open Textbook \(umn.edu\)](https://openstax.org/r/writing-for-success) Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International License, except where otherwise noted.

Argument, Concession/Acknowledgment and Refutation

We have already seen that as a writer of an argumentative essay, you do not just want to present your arguments for or against a certain issue. You need to convince or persuade your readers that your opinion is the valid one. You convince readers by presenting your points of view, by presenting points of view that oppose yours, and by showing why the points of view different from yours are not as valid as yours. These three elements of an argumentative essay are known as argument (your point of view), concession/acknowledgement/counterargument (admission that there is an opposing point of view to yours) and refutation (showing why the counterargument is not valid). Acknowledging points of view different from yours and refuting them makes your own argument stronger. It shows that you have thought about all the sides of the issue instead of thinking only about your own views.

Identifying argument, counterargument, concession and refutation

We will now look at sentences from paragraphs which are part of an argumentative essay and identify these parts. Read the four sentences in each group and decide if each sentence is the argument, the counterargument, the acknowledgement / concession or the refutation. Circle your choice.

A

Schools need to replace paper books with e-books.

argument counterargument acknowledgement refutation

Others believe students will get bad eyesight if they read computer screens instead of paper books.

argument counterargument acknowledgement refutation

There is some truth to this statement.

This pair of sentences shows how the structure of the sentence reflects the point of view of the writer. The argument in the first sentence is that cell phones are convenient. The writer feels this is the important aspect, and thus places it in the independent clause. In the dependent clause, the writer concedes that cell phones isolate people. In contrast, in the second sentence the argument is that cell phones isolate people. The writer feels this is the important aspect and therefore puts this idea in the independent clause. The writer of this sentence concedes that cell phones are convenient, and this concession appears in the dependent clause.

Access original content in the link below:

<https://oercommons.org/courseware/le...99487/overview>

Sample Counterargument Paragraph (Access original content in the link below):

<https://content.bridgepointeducation.com/curriculum/file/a8a84b6b-aa7e-488c-84b8-24bf0aefb0ae/1/Sample%20Counterargument%20Paragraph.pdf>

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5.3: Writing Assignment

Course Objective--Develop students' writing process in composing formal, college-level essays using various rhetorical writing modes.

SLO--Engage in a recursive process of prewriting, drafting, revising, editing, and proofreading; Direct an argument or explanation to the designated audience; Establish a clear framework of essay and paragraph organization appropriate to the writing task and the thesis; Employ rhetorical strategies consistent with the purpose of the writing task; Summarize, analyze, and evaluate the arguments, counterarguments, and evidence in the writing of others.

Writing Assignment

Look at the completed chart of arguments, counterarguments, and counterarguments not considered by the author. Then prepare a short mini essay, approximate 4 to 5 paragraphs, where you address and explain two arguments and their corresponding counterarguments.

The mini essay should follow this structure:

Paragraph 1--introduction stating the author's thesis

Paragraph 2--the author's first argument with one example from the article and/or personal experiences and observations

Paragraph 3--the first counterargument that refutes the first argument mentioned in the previous paragraph. You must use one example from the article and/or personal experiences.

Paragraph 4--the author's second argument with one example from the article and/or personal experiences and observations

Paragraph 5--the second counterargument that refutes the argument stated in the previous paragraph. You must use one example from the article and/or personal experiences.

Remember when preparing to write this mini essay, focus on two significant arguments and their corresponding counterarguments. This will require you to use the point by point strategy in writing an argument and refuting the same point. Also, use transitions to link each paragraph. All examples from the article must be cited using the MLA or APA format.

Assessment Tool

Criteria	Excellent	Good	Satisfactory	Needs Improvement
Thesis/Argument	The thesis statement clearly and concisely states the author's stance	The thesis statement, for the most part, is clear.	The thesis statement is present but does not state a strong argument	The thesis statement is too broad or too factual
Argument	The writer identifies and explains clearly and concisely one argument. Sources are identified when applicable.	For the most part, the writer identifies and explain an argument. Sources are identified when applicable.	The writer identifies an argument but provides some explanation. More supporting evidence is needed. Some sources are not identified when applicable.	The writer fails to identify a specific argument and explain its relevance to the writer's thesis. No sources are identified.
Counterargument	The writer identifies and refutes the argument using reliable evidence as support.	The writer refutes the counterargument. but there are a few lapses in effectiveness or reasoning. For the most part valid or reliable evidence is provided.	The writer provides a rebuttal but additional evidence is needed to strengthen the analysis. The writer sometimes states unsupported generalizations or unimportant details.	The writer fails to provide a rebuttal. The relationship between the argument and counterargument is unclear, underdeveloped or vague.

Cohesion	Effective usage of varied syntax. Effective and varied use of transitions.	Effective use of varied syntax may be inconsistent Effective use of transitions.	There are some lapses in varied syntax. Effective use of transitions is inconsistent	Syntax is not varied. Limited or nonexistent use of transitions
Grammar and Spelling	Correct grammar, spelling and punctuation with little (1 or 2 minor) to no errors	With few exceptions, correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation	Usually correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation. One to three serious errors (run-ons, fragments, comma splices, subject-verb agreement, verb form concerns)	Recurrent grammar, punctuation, and/or spelling concerns disrupt the expression of ideas.
Citation of Sources	All in-text citations are identified correctly using MLA or APA format	With one or two exceptions, all in-text citations are identified correctly using MLA or APA format	Some sources are not correctly identified using MLA or APA format. A review of citation format is needed.	The writer fails to identify any sources.

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